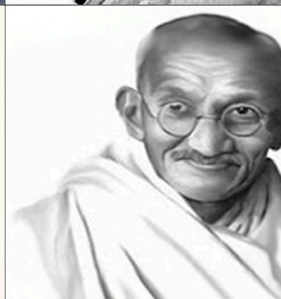


General Knowledge

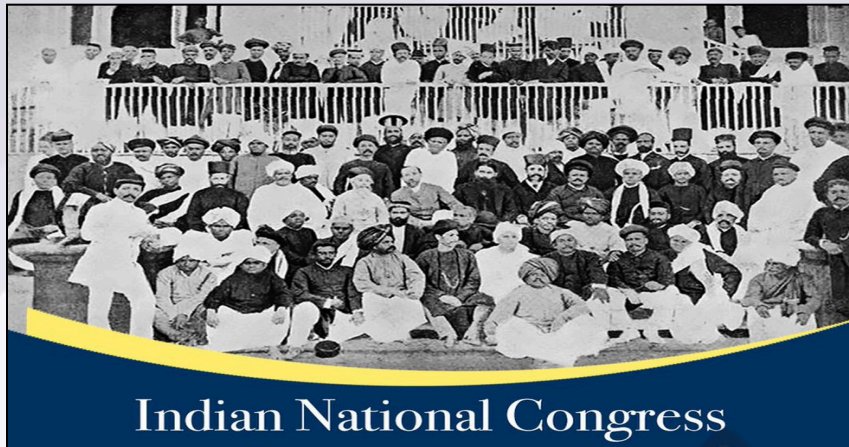
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Indian National Congress Formation

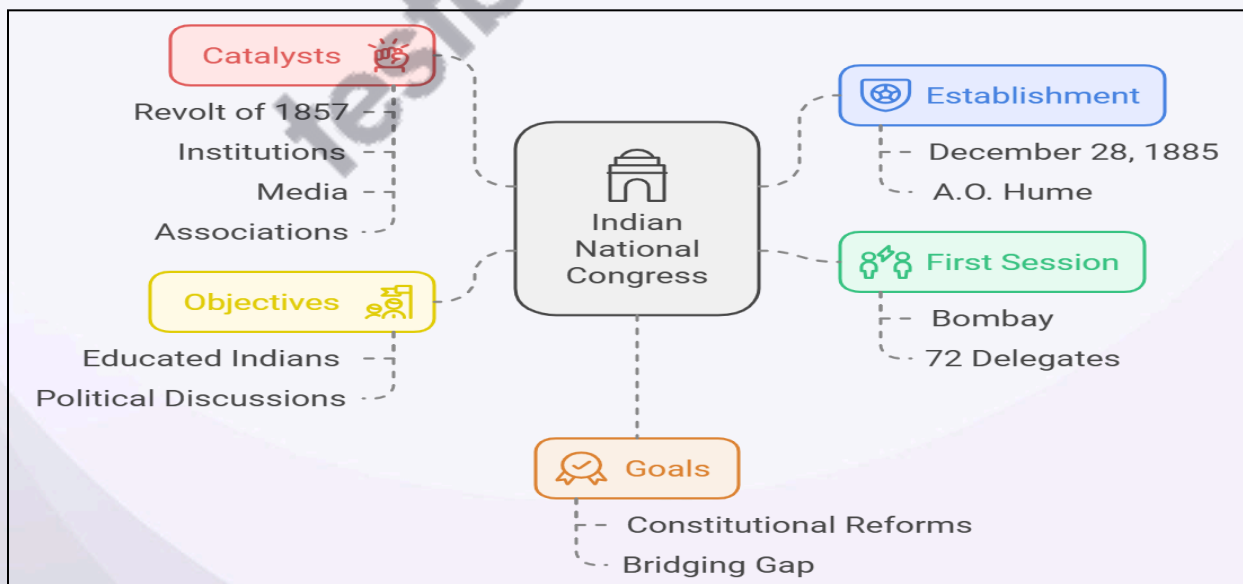


Indian National Congress



Introduction

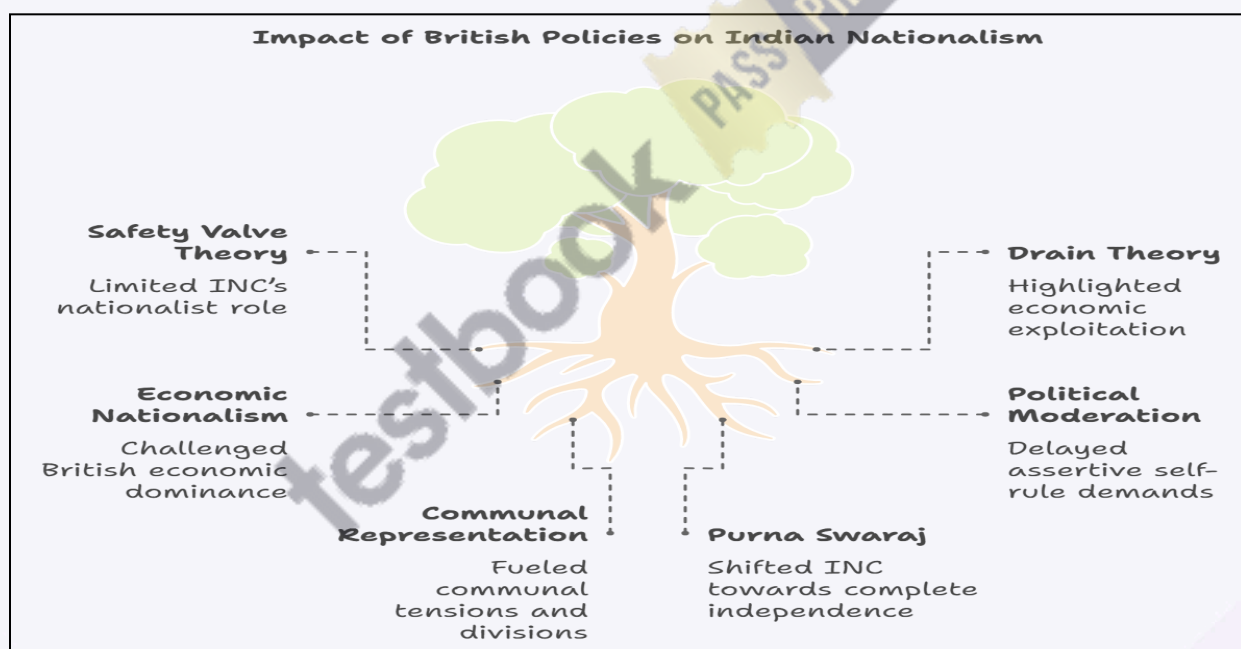
- It was established on **December 28, 1885**, by **A.O. Hume**, a retired British civil servant, the INC served as a platform for political dialogue and moderate demands.
- The first session was held in **Bombay**, attended by **72** delegates from across India.
- It aimed to bring together educated Indians and create a forum for political discussions.
- The INC sought to bridge the gap between British colonial rulers and Indian subjects, hoping for constitutional reforms.
- The rise of social, economic, and political awareness among educated Indians after the **Revolt of 1857** fueled the need for such a platform.



Important Theories:

Theory	Description	Proponents/ Key Figures	Significance
Safety Valve Theory	It proposed that the British supported the formation of the INC as a "safety valve" to allow Indian discontent to be expressed peacefully rather than through rebellion.	Lala Lajpat Rai, A.O. Hume (often associated)	This theory suggests that the INC was formed with British encouragement to contain growing political dissent. However, this view has been debated, with some considering it limiting the INC's nationalist role.
Drain Theory	Proposed that British economic policies were draining India's wealth to Britain, leaving India impoverished.	Dadabhai Naoroji	The Drain Theory highlighted the exploitative nature of British rule and became a cornerstone in arguments for economic independence and reforms.
Economic Nationalism	Argued for developing Indian industries and boycotting British goods to achieve self-reliance and economic independence.	Moderates (e.g., Dadabhai Naoroji), Extremists (e.g., Tilak)	Economic nationalism fueled movements like Swadeshi and Boycott, emphasizing self-reliance and challenging British economic dominance in India.
Theory of Political Moderation	Advocated a moderate, reform-oriented approach to achieving self-rule by working within the British political framework.	Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Pherozeshah Mehta	Moderates believed in constitutional methods and gradual reforms, shaping early Congress policies before the rise of the Extremist faction.
Satyagraha and Non-Violent Resistance	Gandhi's philosophy of non-violent resistance (Satyagraha) emphasized moral force over physical force in the struggle against oppression.	Mahatma Gandhi	Satyagraha transformed the INC, leading to mass participation in movements like Non-Cooperation, Civil Disobedience, and Quit India. It also shaped the overall strategy of the

			Indian freedom struggle.
Swaraj (Self-Rule) and Extremism	Advocated for immediate self-rule and direct action, rejecting gradual reforms and negotiation with the British.	Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal	Extremists promoted a more confrontational approach, influencing the INC's shift from moderate methods to assertive demands for self-rule.
Purna Swaraj (Complete Independence)	The demand for full independence, beyond mere Dominion status, was officially adopted as the INC's goal in 1929.	Jawaharlal Nehru, Lahore Session (1929)	The declaration of Purna Swaraj marked a radical shift in INC's objectives and laid the ideological foundation for the freedom movement's final phase.



Founding and Early Years (1885-1905)

- This period marks the formative years of the Indian National Congress, during which it laid the groundwork for the Indian independence movement.
- The INC, initially a moderate organization, aimed at gradual reform rather than outright independence.

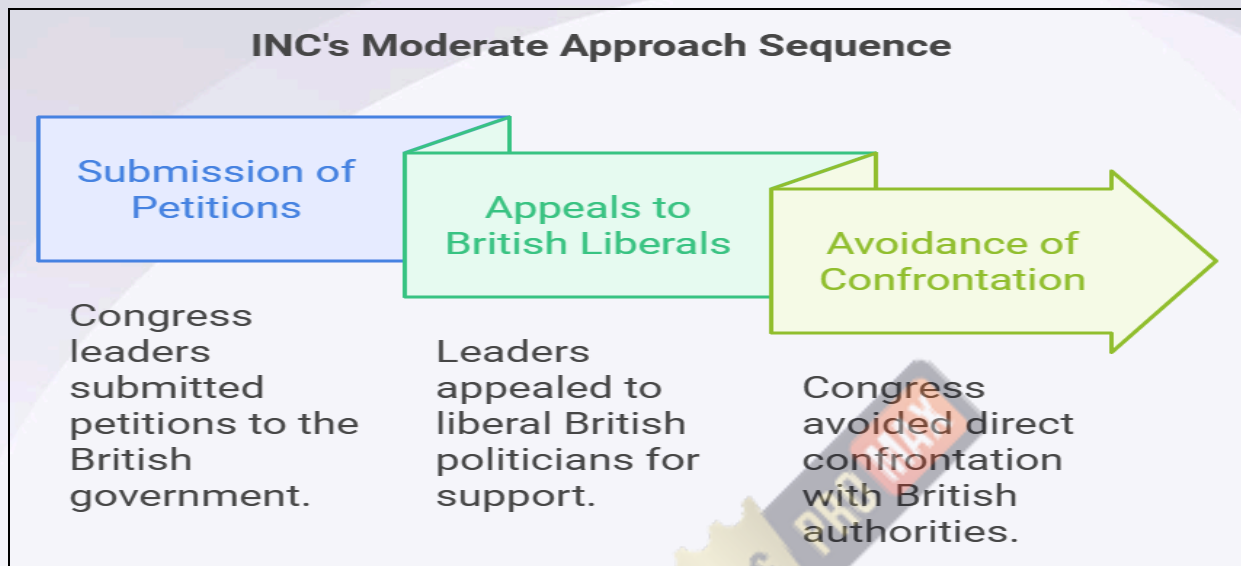
Early Leaders and Key Figures

- **Dadabhai Naoroji:** He was also known as the “**Grand Old Man of India**,” Naoroji was one of the earliest leaders to highlight the British exploitation of India. His famous “**Drain Theory**” argued that British policies were draining India’s wealth to England. Naoroji’s works and speeches were instrumental in raising awareness about the adverse economic impacts of British rule.
- **Ferozeshah Mehta:** A prominent Parsi leader, lawyer, and politician, Mehta played a key role in establishing the Bombay Municipal Corporation and served as its president.
- His contributions to urban planning and advocacy for Indian representation in governance were significant in advancing the INC’s objectives.
- **Badruddin Tyabji:** As the third president of the INC (1887), Tyabji was notable for his efforts in fostering **Hindu-Muslim unity**. His participation symbolized the inclusive nature of the Congress, which aimed to bring together people from all religions and communities in India.
- **Dinshaw Wacha:** An early Congress leader, Wacha was deeply concerned with economic issues, including currency policy and public debt.
- His advocacy for fiscal responsibility within the British administration reflected the Congress’s broader goals of economic self-reliance and protection from exploitative policies.
- These leaders were instrumental in shaping the INC’s moderate approach, which relied on petitions, constitutional reforms, and appeals to British authorities rather than confrontation.

Objectives of the INC

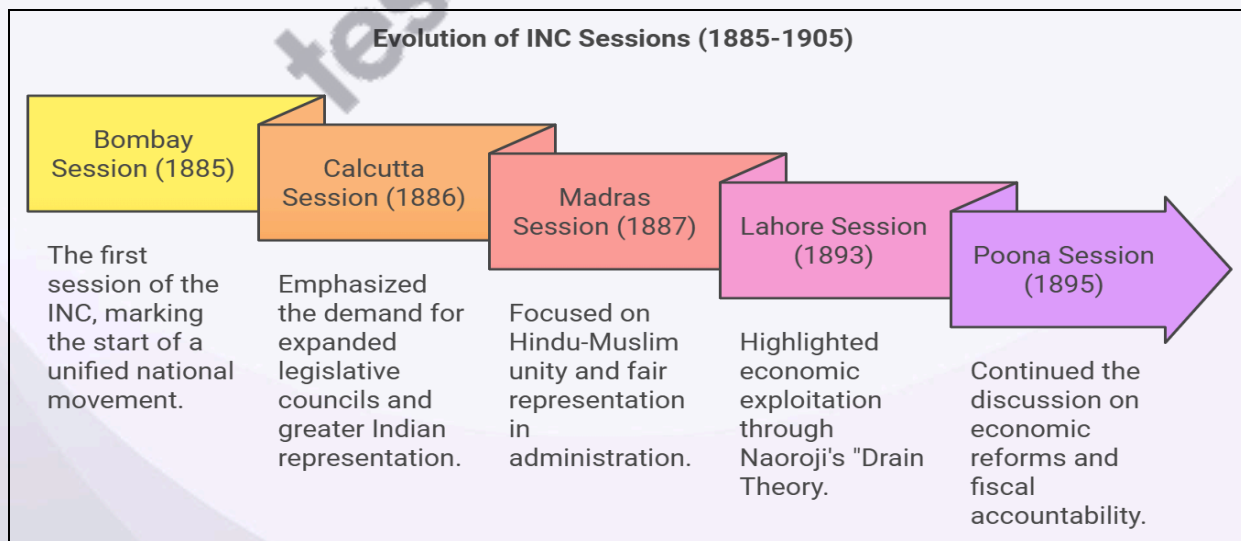
- The initial objectives of the INC were moderate, as it sought to establish a dialogue with British authorities rather than demand complete independence.
- Key objectives during the early years included:
 - **Greater Representation:** The INC advocated for greater Indian representation in legislative councils at both central and provincial levels.
 - This was seen as a way to ensure that Indians had a voice in decisions affecting their welfare and to hold British officials accountable.
 - **Economic Reforms:** Leaders sought to address policies that were detrimental to India’s economy. The Congress called for reducing the military budget (which was funded by Indian taxpayers), revising the land revenue system, and curbing unnecessary expenditures that burdened the Indian population.
 - **Reduction of Military Expenditure:** The INC argued that a significant portion of India’s revenue was being diverted towards maintaining a large British army in India. Congress leaders urged the British to cut military expenses and use the funds for India’s social and economic development instead.
 - **Opposition to Heavy Taxation:** Excessive taxes on agricultural produce and manufactured goods severely impacted Indian farmers and traders.

- **Awareness and Political Unity:** Another core objective was to spread political awareness and create a sense of unity among Indians from different regions and communities. This was especially important in an era where regional and communal divides were often emphasized by the colonial government.



Significant Sessions of the INC (1885-1905)

- **Objectives of the INC:** Emphasis on greater representation, economic reforms, and opposition to heavy taxation.
 - Understanding these objectives helps clarify why the INC was founded and how it laid the groundwork for later independence movements.
- **Moderate Approach and Methods:** The INC's preference for petitions, appeals, and constitutional methods is crucial to understanding the organization's initial strategies.



Moderates and Extremists (1905-1919)

- During this period, the **Indian National Congress (INC)** witnessed a crucial ideological shift.
- The debate between **Moderates** and **Extremists** marked the growing frustration among Indian leaders with the British government's refusal to address India's socio-political and economic issues.
- This shift began a more assertive phase in India's freedom movement.

Partition of Bengal (1905)

- The Partition of Bengal was implemented on **October 16, 1905**, by then Viceroy of India, **Lord Curzon**.
- Bengal was divided into two parts: **East Bengal**, with a Muslim majority, and West Bengal, with a Hindu majority.
- Officially, the British argued that Bengal was too large to administer efficiently, and partitioning it would ensure better governance. However, many Indians believed the true motive was to divide and weaken nationalist sentiments by creating religious and cultural divisions.
- The decision triggered widespread protests across India, particularly in Bengal, where people viewed the partition as an attempt to curb the growing unity among Indians and weaken the nationalist movement.

Impact on the INC

- The opposition to the partition intensified divisions within the INC, as some leaders (Moderates) advocated a diplomatic response, while others (Extremists) believed in direct action.
- The partition ultimately became a catalyst for the ideological split in the INC.

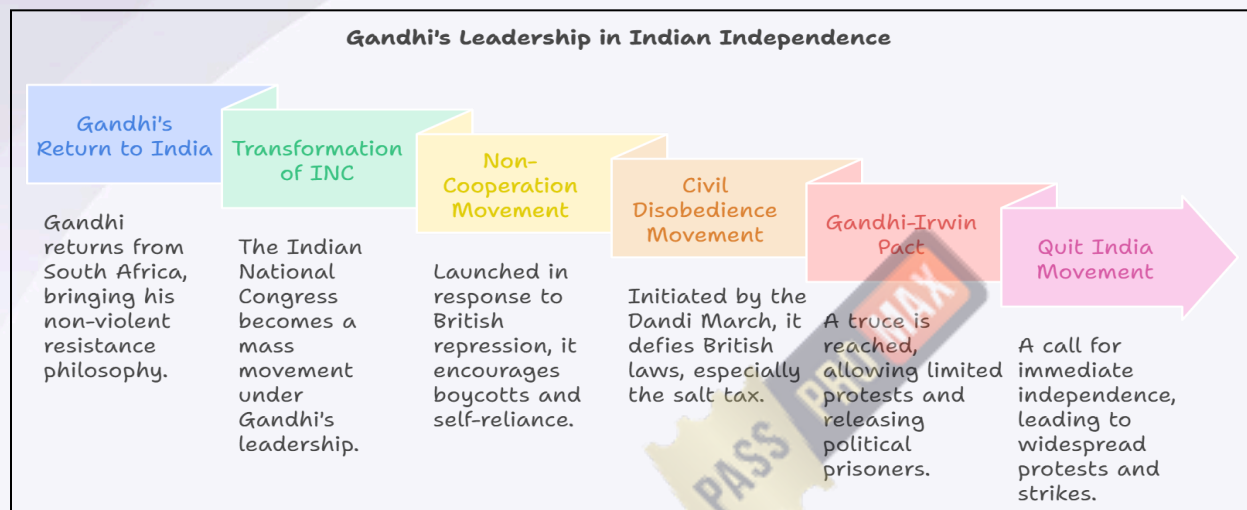
Swadeshi and Boycott Movement

- **Swadeshi (Self-Reliance):** The Swadeshi movement encouraged Indians to use indigenous products and boycott British goods as a means of economic resistance.
- This included the promotion of Indian textiles, handicrafts, and industries, as well as a call for self-reliance.
- **Boycott of British Goods:** The boycott movement urged Indians to refuse British-made products, especially textiles, as a form of economic protest. People burned British cloth and instead wore khadi (Indian-made fabric).
- **Expansion of Swadeshi:** Beyond economic independence, the Swadeshi movement extended to the realms of education, industry, and social reform. Leaders established national schools, colleges, and industries to foster Indian entrepreneurship and cultural pride.
- **Mass Involvement:** The Swadeshi and Boycott movements led to mass participation by people across India. These movements marked one of the first times that Indians from

diverse backgrounds joined together in a nationwide protest, setting the stage for future mass movements.

- **Legacy:** The Swadeshi and Boycott movements laid the foundation for India's economic self-reliance. They also helped instill a sense of national pride and unity, reinforcing the belief that Indians could be self-sufficient without British control.

The Era of Gandhi and Non-Cooperation (1920-1942)



INC and Role in Independence Struggle (1942-1947)

- During this period, the Indian National Congress (INC) intensified its demand for full independence, leading to the final mass movement, the **Quit India Movement**.
- Various negotiations were attempted to address Indian political aspirations and to determine the post-war governance of India, ultimately resulting in independence.

Quit India Movement (1942)

- By 1942, British involvement in World War II had taken a toll on India. The failure of the Cripps Mission, which offered limited self-governance after the war, led to frustration among Indian leaders. Additionally, the INC opposed India's participation in the **war** without any consultation with Indian leaders.
 - On **August 8, 1942**, at the Bombay session, Gandhi launched the Quit India Movement with the slogan "**Do or Die**," calling for an immediate end to British rule.
 - This was the first time the INC openly demanded British withdrawal without negotiation.
- The primary objective was **Purna Swaraj** (complete independence).
 - The INC urged Indians to refuse cooperation with the British in every form.
- Key Features:

- Mass Protests and Strikes: People organized protests, strikes, and demonstrations across the country, demanding the British to “**Quit India.**”
- **Civil Disobedience:** Indians stopped working in British-run institutions, refused to pay taxes, and boycotted British goods.
- The British quickly arrested Gandhi, Nehru, and most prominent Congress leaders. With the leadership in jail, the movement saw spontaneous uprisings, led by grassroots leaders, students, women, and common citizens.
- Leaders like **Jayaprakash Narayan, Ram Manohar Lohia, and Aruna Asaf Ali** went underground to continue the resistance.
- They coordinated strikes, distributed pamphlets, and organized sabotage activities against the British.
- The British administration responded with severe repression, including mass arrests, public beatings, and shootings. They imposed curfews and censored the press, leading to widespread violence.
- Though the movement was eventually suppressed, it demonstrated to the British that India was ungovernable without Indian cooperation.
- It unified Indians in an unprecedented way, and the intense popular resistance underscored that **British rule** could no longer continue without significant opposition.

Role During World War II

- At the outbreak of **World War II** in **1939**, the British unilaterally declared India a belligerent without consulting Indian leaders.
- This decision led to strong resentment from the INC, which had always advocated for a say in India’s governance.
- The INC offered to support the British war effort only if India was granted immediate independence, which the British refused. In response, Congress ministries in various provinces resigned in protest in **1939**.
- British policies during the war further strained relations between the INC and the British. Economic resources were heavily exploited, and India faced rising inflation, shortages, and famine in some regions, notably the **Bengal Famine** of **1943**.
- While the INC opposed British involvement, the Muslim League saw the war as an opportunity to strengthen its position. League leaders supported the British war effort, leading to increased British support for their demand for a separate Muslim state.
- The contrasting positions of the INC and the **Muslim League** during the war created further divisions and set the stage for later communal conflicts.

